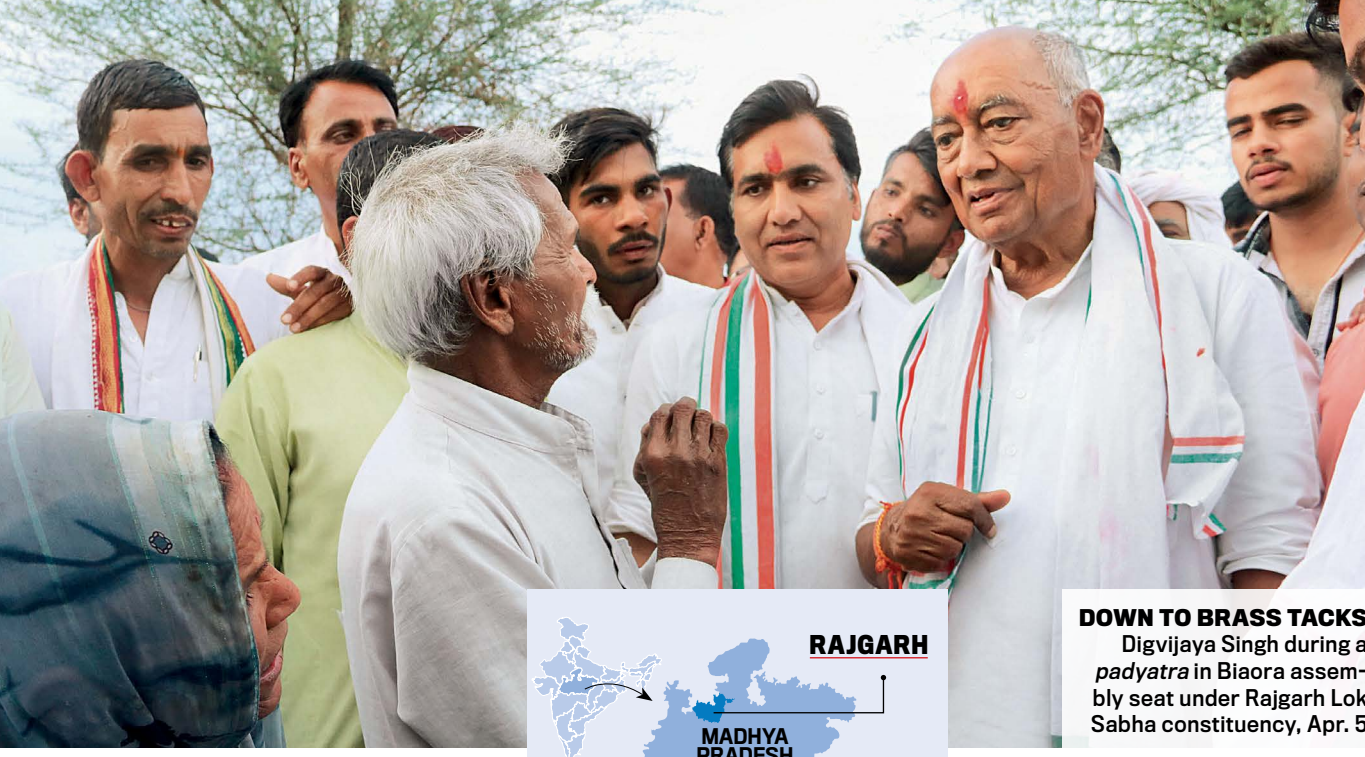
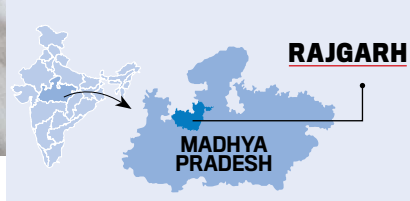


IMRAN KHAN MANSURI

DOWN TO BRASS TACKS
Digvijaya Singh during a *padyatra* in Biaora assembly seat under Rajgarh Lok Sabha constituency, Apr. 5



2019

WINNER	RUNNER-UP
Rodmal Nagar (BJP)	Mona Sustani (Congress)
65.4% vote share	31.2% vote share

2014

WINNER	RUNNER-UP
Rodmal Nagar (BJP)	Narayan Singh Amlabe (Congress)
59% vote share	36.4% vote share

man served four terms from Rajgarh before switching to the BJP just before the 2004 election, when he won again. However, he lost to the Congress's Narayan Singh Amlabe in 2009. Presently, six out of the eight Vidhan Sabha segments in the Lok Sabha constituency are held by the BJP and the remaining two are with the Congress, including Raghogarh, Singh's former assembly seat, now held by his son Jai Vardhan. In the outgoing assembly, the Congress had MLAs in five assembly segments, which displayed its local firepower.

State BJP spokesperson Ashish Agarwal dismisses the Digvijaya challenge. "Rajgarh is a citadel of nationalist thought," he says. "The electorate here will never allow someone like Digvijaya Singh who disrespects sanatan dharma to win. The Rajgarh election will prove to be the end of his political career." The politics of Hindutva will be a formidable challenge for the Congress in Rajgarh. If MP is considered the laboratory of the Sangh Parivar, Rajgarh has hosted some of its most skilled operatives. Although the Muslim population is relatively small, communal tensions in Narsinghgarh, Talen and Rajgarh town have deepened the Hindu-Muslim divide. "Muslims reacted to everything, but have been quiet ever since the BJP came to power in the state and at the Centre," says Satish Dangi of Sonkatch. The village prominently displays slogans in support of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, with saffron flags fluttering in almost every house. The electorate also has a long memory. "In 2003, the Digvijaya government distributed common *charnoi* lands to Dalits and Scheduled Tribes. Subsequently, the beneficiaries sold their *kabzas* to others, leaving villagers with no space for their cattle," adds Satish. This controversial decision, part of a pro-Dalit initiative, is believed to have led to a rift between the Dalits and OBCs, with the latter overwhelmingly supporting the BJP—a significant factor in Singh's defeat in the 2003 assembly polls.

BY MAKING THE CONTEST A RODMAL NAGAR VS DIGVIJAYA SINGH ONE INSTEAD OF MODI VS SINGH, THE CONGRESS BELIEVES IT CAN DENY THE BJP A HAT TRICK IN RAJGARH

Cut to now. The incumbent MP, Nagar, is drawing the electorate's ire for being inactive but is hoping the Modi phenomenon will see him through. "Nagar has done nothing for this village in the past decade. If it is a choice between Raja Sahab (as Singh is called locally) and Nagar, we will support Raja Sahab, but we also like Modi," comments Shyam Julania, a shopkeeper in Malawar village.

Here, Singh once again reminds the electorate to approach the election as they would a panchayat poll. "There are 2,236 polling booths in the constituency. If you can secure victory at your booth through hard work, we will win," he asserts. Every day, Singh covers two dozen villages in 12 hours. In every village, he addresses a *chaupal*-level public meeting. His campaign began with a *padyatra* in all eight assembly seats. The idea is to keep it small—no big leaders, no big public meetings.

Water scarcity is a theme that runs across villages in Rajgarh. While tap connections and tanks have been set up in many areas, there's no supply. "The groundwater level is below 500 feet here, and tube wells dry up at the start of summer. Simply providing tap water isn't the solution; we need more water bodies," says Radheshyam Dangi from Sonkatch. There's no shortage of promises to address the issue. Keeping them is the problem. ■